Paris Branch

# Newsletter

**N° 48 – June 2026**



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**Chairman's introduction, June 2026.**

June, of course, celebrates the 82nd anniversary of the D-Day landings. I have been unable, personally, to attend the ceremonies in Normandy this year but several of our members have managed to go. Caroline Clopet, Bill Beauclerk, Robin Sweeney and Rosemary Rudland were all on the spot.

You can see some of the photos taken on our Facebook page, also some photos that are included in this newsletter.

Bill Beauclerk and I attended a ceremony at the Arc de Triomphe in memory of the French Resistance.

We once again had a very enjoyable monthly lunch which was well attended, and very kindly provided by Ifekoya Arinola. Thank you Ifekoya.

We also had the film night, showing the modern version of the film "Dunkirk". Attendance was low, however and we hope that you will be more numerous to attend this month's film on the 16th when "The Longest Day" will be projected. One of our American members Nick Marshal will be attending along with, hopefully, members of the Paris branch of the American Legion who have been invited. We might even attract some new members, given our excellent facilities.

Our June lunch will be held on the 18th. Julie Knapp has volunteered to provide it for which we are most grateful. I hope a good number of you will attend. Just email me to let me know if you will be attending. You will find the menu in the text below.

Finally, as there won't be a lunch in July, please do remember that our annual ceremony at the Arc de Triomphe will take place on the 4th August. We expect to see, as usual, a good turn out of our members there.

Hope to see you at the lunch, film night and at the Arch on 4th August.

Best,

Richard

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## June Quiz 2026



1. The War of the Roses was ended when Lancastrian forces defeated Yorkist supporters in the final battle of the war. In which county did the final battle take place?

2. In this month in 1936, Gone with the Wind was first published. Who was the author?

3. In 1913, Emily Davison a women's suffrage activist was fatally injured. How?

4. In 1883 the train line that is identified with intrigue and luxury travel started operations. What is it called?

5. On 15th June 1215 which significant document was signed by King John limiting the power of the monarchy?

6. In June 1949 George Orwell published his political novel of life under a totalitarian government. What was it called?

7. In 1862, General Stonewall Jackson concluded his Shenandoah Valley Campaign. In which war?

8. The first Boat race held on the Thames between Oxford and Cambridge took place in June of which year.
   Was it a) 1829 b) 1849 c) 1869

9. On her birthday, in 1942, Anne Frank began keeping a diary. How old was she?

10. International Olympic Committee to reinstate the ancient Olympic Games. Who led the committee?

**Janet Warby**

## Obituary

*Alison Thorn writes to inform us of the death of her father Lt Cmdr. Michael Healy MBE. A fascinating personality, I recall his visits to the Paris branch a long time ago now. Rumour in Paris was that in the poppy season he would sail around the luxury boats in Monaco harbour and make more in contributions to the poppy appeal than the total of all the other branches in France. Here is Alison's letter:*

A little late, largely due to complications with French bureaucracy, I wanted to let you and members of the Paris branch know of the recent death of my father, Michael Healy. He died in Nice on 3rd February at the great age of 95 after a fascinating life. He was a very active Chairman of the Nice-Monaco branch of the Royal British Legion for thirty years. A few years ago he was awarded the RBL Gold medal for his work for the Legion. He raised over 250,000 euros almost single handedly and did a huge amount of welfare work for serving and past servicemen and women and their dependents. When he stepped down as Chairman and handed the reins over to Elaine Dempster, who he had recruited as Poppy Appeal organiser some years before, he was appointed Honorary Life President. My father regularly visited Paris and I think would have been known to your members. I recall he often attended the RBL Ambassador's cocktail party. He was a regular reader of the Paris branch newsletter and was impressed by the work of the Paris branch.

You can read a biography of Lt Cdr Healy here

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## Events





Rosemary Rudland laid a wreath on behalf of the RBL at the " Ceremony to honour the flag-bearers and servicemen from Normandy " *(Cérémonie de remerciement en hommage aux porte-drapeaux et militaires de Normandie) on 17 May 2026 in Saint-Pierre-en-Auge (Calvados).*

Unique in France, and organised for the second year running by the Souvenir Français, it gathered more than a hundred flag-bearers with many notable military and civil dignitaries.

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5 June 2026 – British War Cemetery, Douvres-la-Délivrande.
A very moving ceremony in honour of Mr Manh Thông Dao, the new mayor, attended by civil and military authorities.
Delighted to represent the Royal British Legion – Paris, France, and to meet Mr Baptiste Prevost, Deputy Director, representing the Commonwealth War Graves Commission.




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5 June 2026. Honoured to represent The Royal British Legion – Paris branch at the British Ceremony of Remembrance held at the British Garden-Caen Memorial.
The event was marked by the poignant presence of two centenarian veterans of the Battle of Normandy, William Rice and Ken Hay.
The occasion was presided over by Major General O.C.C. Brown CBE, Commander of the 3rd British Division.

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6 juin 2026 -Courseulles-sur-Mer - Juno Beach Centre.
We were called upon to lay wreaths together with the Normandy branch....
A Canadian commemorative Ceremony in the presence of Her Excellency Ms Nathalie DROUIN, Ambassador of Canada in France."
Wreaths laid by: Royal British Legion – Paris France) et Tom Wilson (Royal British Legion - Normandy).

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6 June 2026. Bayeux War Cemetery. An impressive commemoration ceremony organised by the Commonwealth War Graves Commission and the Royal British Legion, attended by senior British officials. The rain cleared just in time for me to lay a wreath on behalf of the Royal British Legion.

*(Above photos Yvan Barbieri)*

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## Events Coming Up

The June lunch



**Don't forget to book in for this month's lunch.**

**Thursday 18 June**
**1215 for 1230**
**Only €20 - Pay on the day**
**(in cash please)**

Contact Richard at 06 45 10 47 70 or richard.neave05@gmail.com
*Reserve early to be sure of a place.*
*(Cancellations up to 48h before)*




*LUNCH MENU*
*Thursday 18 June*

*STARTER·*
*Gazpacho*

*MAIN COURSE·*
*Cold salmon (cooked en papillotte with dill, onion, bay leaf & lemon)*

*DESSERT· To be decided*

*Wine served with the meal*

*Coffee or tea*

(N.B. - TBC = To be confirmed)

| Date | Month | Venue | Time |
|---|---|---|---|
| Thursday | 16 June | Film evening | 12h15 for 12h30 |
| Tuesday | 18 June | Lunch at Clubhouse | 18h00 - 21h30 |
| Thursday | June | Lunch at Clubhouse | 12h15 for 12h30 |
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In the event of additions or changes you will be notified as information becomes available. For a fuller account of the year's events click here

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## A Wartime Childhood – by *Stewart Miller*

I was born in 1931, and spent my childhood in Richings Park, Iver, in Buckinghamshire, went to school there and later in Slough. I had an elder sister and a younger brother. Thus I was 8 years old when WW2 broke out, and 13 when it ended, sufficiently old to have some appreciation of the momentous events which were taking place over this period.

While I am still able to, it seems not to be unreasonable to set out a few of the recollections of what it was like for a youngster to live through this dangerous and exciting period during which Winston Churchill was Prime Minister and astounded the English-speaking world with his most remarkable speeches.

I clearly recall the 1939 declaration of war with Nazi Germany over the BBC radio, initially a non-event. This was to change after a period of an uneasy peace until France fell and the Luftwaffe, now having bases in occupied France, embarked on a systematic daylight bombing on London. Winston Churchill was appointed Prime Minister.

Night bombing was soon to follow with London visibly on fire each night and German bombers overhead en route to other objectives in Britain. We, as children, took nightly shelter under the stairs which were reputed to be the safest place of refuge. Searchlights and anti-air gunfire became the new normality. My father enlisted with the newly formed Civil Defence as a Fire Guard Officer with HQ nearby. Home Guard and air raid wardens were now a daily and nightly feature. Their principal preoccupation at night was to ensure that the blackout regulations were properly observed but there was also food rationing, the carrying of gasmasks, the maintaining of a stock of iron rations in each household, air raid shelters to build and supervise. Everyone had an ID number, mine was DWIK 385/4.

For safety, our Gran and aunt fled from the East London bombing to live with us.

The speeches of Winston Churchill were largely responsible for the maintenance of morale at a period when many believed that the invasion of our shores from France was imminent.

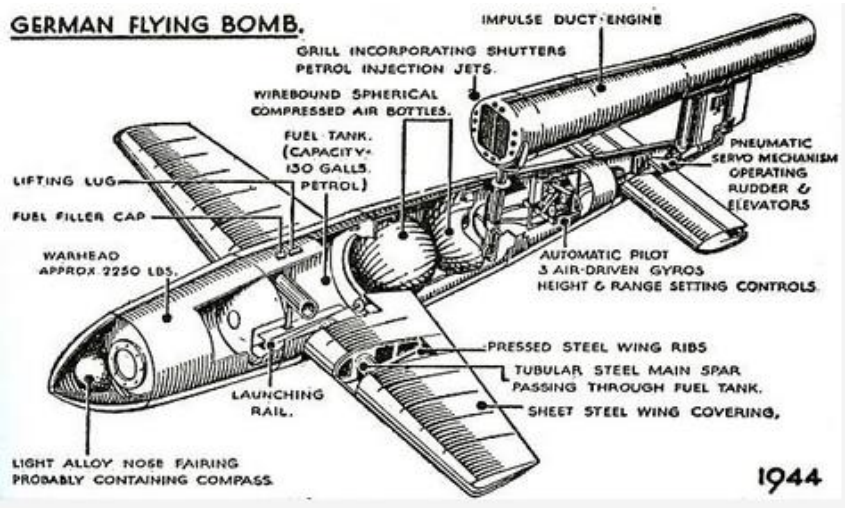
I recall the opening phases of the Battle of Britain, Hawker Hurricanes and Supermarine Spitfires engaging the enemy with contrails in the summer sky – high drama for observers, especially younger ones. Then there was the evacuation of the British Army from Dunkirk in small boats, some from the nearby Thames. Called Operation Dynamo, it involved the rescue of more than 338,000 British and French soldiers from the French port of Dunkirk between 26 May and 4 June 1940. Sometimes referred to as the Miracle of Dunkirk, it was a boost for British morale. However, soon afterwards, the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbour came as an unpleasant surprise.



Post WW2, Hawker Aircraft Ltd factory at Langley near Slough (just off the M4 at Datchet turn-off) with numerous Tempests (and one Hurricane) in front of the Production Hangars. Remarkably, substantial portions of the airfield and buildings remain.

Close by, in Langley, the Hawker Aircraft factory was expanded with a 24/7 labour force enlisted. Originally producing Hawker Hurricanes, it quickly added the Typhoon, The Tempest and the Fury to its repertoire and, in 1942/43, became a popular target for the Luftwaffe's night bombing raids. This was our first exposure to actual danger and was terrifying to we youngsters. RAF Bomber Command HQ, located in the mansion of the one-time Duke of Bathurst in the Parkland, compromised, was hurriedly relocated to High Wycombe.

My brother and I were evacuated to North Somerset at this time, which was safer than living close to target areas, from there, just across the Bristol Channel, we witnessed the firebombing of South Wales harbours and steelworks. We attended school, along with many other evacuees from various targeted areas. I recall the speeches of Winston Churchill, morale-raising in desperate times with the possible invasion of our shores from across the Channel in France.




In 1943, I returned home to Richings Park. It was about then that the missile bombing, the V1 Doodle Bug appeared, a new menace and we experienced a near miss when in London. Now living close to London, we boys were able to watch football matches at Tottenham and Reading, where professional players in army or RAF uniforms made up the teams.

There was cricket too, with county teams playing at Lord's. We were regular attendees. One day we were watching the army playing the RAF there with around 5000 spectators when the ominous drone of a V1 Doodlebug became apparent. Silence fell as the crowd awaited the classic warning signal, not the noise of the missile's engine but the terrifying moment when it stopped. It did. heads went down and the players on the field fell flat on the pitch. The missile landed close to the back of the stand where we were seated. The explosion was huge, but surprisingly, there were no casualties. The players calmly got to their feet and carried on the game.

After the V1, the V2 targeting of London was to follow with shattering effect. My grandfather joined us from London then and was employed in the production of the Hawker Typhoon in Langley. I remember him, at the age of 75 dressed in his pre-war pin-striped three-piece suit with a watch and chain, his wartime dress code.

On one of the Luftwaffe raids on Hawkers, I recall the whole area terrifyingly lit up, almost as bright as day, by flares from the bombers as they attacked the factory. My brother and I were supposed to be in the air raid shelter but couldn't resist watched the flares from the lawn in our pyjamas instead.



On the other hand, bomber Command Avro Lancasters engaged in nightly bombing of Germany, and US B-17s in daylight bombing, overflew our home incessantly. In 1943-44, forces from Free Poland and Canada were accommodated in our area. Then they all suddenly disappeared. That was when, on 6th June 1944, with countless formations of DC-3s overflying to targets in northern France, Winston Churchill addressed the nation. D-Day was in the offing.

In 1945, with the end of war in Europe and the defeat of Nazi Germany, I found myself in Royal Navy uniform, aged 14 years, joining the Training Ship Mercury on the river Hamble, Southampton Water, in preparation for joining the Royal Navy as a Boy Seaman (1947) in Gosport, with the start of a long career that was to follow.

***Stewart Miller***

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## A Word in your Ear – Wartime Words

Most of you, living in France are almost sure to be aware of the origin of the slang word "plonk" meaning a bottle of cheap wine. It comes, of course, from the first war British soldiers pronunciation of the French word *"blanc"* and I am sure the bistros of the time quickly learned that it could refer to any old sort of wine.
There are, however, other words resulting from WW1. Here is a short and by no means exhaustive selection:
"Skive" is still in use to describe the evasive efforts of someone trying to avoid an unpleasant task. It comes from the French *"esquiver"* of similar meaning.
"Over the top" was, of course to launch an - often suicidal – attack. It's meaning these days to describe an excessive approach or going too far, rather like "pushing it a bit".
"Dud" is a bit more complicated and is probably related to the Dutch *"dood"* for dead. It was used well before the war but in a different context to describe something useless. The plural "duds" is still used for – probably old and worn – clothes. In the war it became a much-used term for an unexploded bomb or shell and retains something of that meaning today but in a wider context.
"In a flap" is an interesting and rather picturesque naval introduction relating to the behaviour of seabirds flocking together.



Clearly, the curious and unfamiliar environment of the war created the necessity for new vocabulary. It is probably the same for any radical change in human circumstances. One could probably draw a comparison with the introduction of Electricity, the telephone, the computer – and a new one – AI, ChatGPT and robotics will certainly generate even more words to strain our comprehension as they creep into common use.

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## The Last Laugh

## Botswana Tourist Information Office

**Tourist:** I'm looking for information on tourist facilities in the area.

**Advisor:** Yes. You've come to the right place. There're a lot of leaflets over there.

**Tourist:** Yes, but I've been through the brochures, and I can't seem to find what we want.

**Advisor:** And what would that be sir?

**Tourist:** This is our first time in Botswana and we're not used to the heat. Where can we go for a swim?

**Advisor:** Well, I'm sorry but we don't have a swimming pool in town. I suggest you have a nice cool bath in your hotel.

**Tourist:** That's not at all the same thing. You must have a place where we can have a swim.

**Advisor:** I'm sorry but I'm afraid we don't.

**Tourist:** Well, what's that big river doing out there? I can see it from here. It looks lovely.

**Advisor:** Oh, I couldn't advise you to go swimming there!

**Tourist:** Why? Is there some ridiculous local regulation against it?

**Advisor:** Not at all!. It's not against the law.

**Tourist:** It's polluted then, is it? I know that's a big problem in some African rivers.

**Advisor:** No. The water is fine here. We get our drinking water straight from the river.

**Tourist:** Dangerous currents then? Do people get drowned there?

**Advisor:** Never here. Nothing like that. Very few people swim out there though.

**Tourist:** So, you can't stop us from bathing in the river then if there's no law against it and if the water's all right.

**Advisor:** Well, I can't stop you, but if you insist at least pay attention to the time. Don't go around four in the afternoon.

**Tourist:** But that's when it's hottest. It's the very time you most need a swim. Why on earth shouldn't we go swimming at four o'clock?

**Advisor:** Because that's when they feed the crocodiles sir.

M.Y. (80)

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## June quiz: Answers:



| | |
|---|---|
| 1. Nottinghamshire<br>2. Margaret Mitchell<br>3. Trampled by King George V's horse at the Epsom Derby<br>4. The Orient Express<br>5. Magna Carta | 6. Nineteen Eighty-four<br>7. American Civil War<br>8. 1829<br>9. 13<br>10. Pierre de Coubertin |

*Comments & contributions to mfyates@gmail.com*
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